

BECOMING DANGEROUS

WITCHY FEMMES, QUEER CONJURERS, AND MAGICAL REBELS ON SUMMONING THE POWER TO RESIST

EDITED BY KATIE WEST & JASMINE ELLIOTT

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Simulating Control

Nora Khan

I am on a swept virtual rampart before a stoic virtual fortress overlooking a roiling virtual sea, dappled in warm virtual afternoon light. I am in one of the earliest chapters of *Dark Souls II*, easily one of the most punitive games of all time, a title built for masochists. According to recent statistics, forty-two players die every second in the game, clocking over 150,000 mortalities per hour. The average player, regardless of their skill level, dies tens of thousands of times. A pillar in the centre of the game holds count of how many players have died and continue to die. This unreal glut of deaths is the running joke of the game; it is a fact, a given, an ever-lengthening asymptote to climb up and along. Each move and act in this world is defined by the high chance of being just moments away from perishing. This makes *Dark Souls II* a very lonely game.

In this small coastal town, I slow down in a wheat field and breathe, watch the sun setting on the bluffs, on the gorgeous

ruins, on the wheat. I gather focus before the next plunge through the broken archway, down the path, on into impossible battle. I am in a blissful space between this brief, brilliant life and yet another resurrection by a campfire. This town feels like a space of resistance to that cycle, as it is both out of real time and the game's time. The stones look swept clean, now wildly lit red and gold by the setting sun. The game's harmless NPCs—its mages, gatekeepers, soldiers, priestesses—are all still present, but they register on the periphery of my awareness, skirting around this calm with their bickering, digging, and nervous guarding. I forget my likely-futile mission—to un-petrify a statue, to find a cleric's sacred chime, some old-as-hell feather, some futuristic shards with necromantic properties, I am sure. I look over the water. The peace here brings me to a standstill.

The oceanside fortress is deeply familiar. I am shot through with nostalgia. I have been here before, somewhere in my mind. I linger at its base, before its modest steps, now something like a hundred deaths deep. Not only have I been here before, but I have built almost precisely this fortress by the ocean before and many hundreds of times. I have constructed it from foundation to spire. The exact shape, colouring, and position of the mental fortress changes each time, as it is a hyperreal composite of all the fortresses by the ocean outside of vaguely medieval towns in dozens of dungeon crawlers I have played through the late 1980s and 1990s to the present. But as in this game, the specifics of the fortress are not quite as important as the feeling it produces as a controlled space, its reveal of itself within an order of movement. The overlook of the fortress by the sea is consolation after a struggle. It has only opened up before me after I have

moved up through its dungeon, so I can watch the sunlight cut across the stone sides, widening angles in high drama.

My own mental game begins in a narrow stone corridor at the opening of a dungeon. I am tussling with a yowling mass, an abstract object that takes on various faces before receding back into amorphousness. The room is hellish, meaning blood-lit. I grip this tulpa, which manifests a trauma—a cluster of harmful words, a violence, a painful memory of harm—and then place it firmly on the floor to flail and direct its gruesome energies at me. I watch it and then walk backwards, slow as though through water, keeping the flailing being steady in my vision, distancing myself from it physically and emotionally with each step. I pause, and a metal dungeon door, substantial, several feet thick, studded around its grated windows, slides down from overhead. There is a delicious ch-chunk as it clicks past me, rolls down, and slams. To ensure its heaviness and its solidity, I press myself madly against the door, press and press to try to get back to the other side, until I slide down against the wall onto the ground, my legs weak from the effort. I can hear the psychic detritus, still activated, but its noise is fainter.

When I have exhausted myself against the door, I walk forward several feet, the map of the ground opening up before me. Behind me, another heavy door slides down and shakes the ground as it hits. I press against it to try to hear the noise of the object. Its outlines are dimmer now. It is secured in a closed space, neutralised. I walk forward, and the stone corridor begins to widen, the torches leading up a winding way. Another door rolls down behind me. Four steps, and then another. Four

steps. Registering each shuddering gate, I walk past torches to the end of the hall, to the base of a wide stairway that curves up into the black.

Why am I even here, in this dungeon? The simple answer is that my brain has slotted me here to map my way out of the grip of a demon that usually represents a traumatic event or a flashback rooted in complex post-traumatic stress disorder (CPTSD), emerging from a childhood and early life dismantled by emotional and physical violence. In order to get through the day, I need to be able to separate myself quickly from the memory or event; it will debilitate me if I cannot protect myself, effectively deflect, and reconstitute myself from the ground up. When I am stuck on a traumatic episode from ten, twenty years ago, I'm sixteen, six years old again. I am there. I am seeing and feeling it all again. The flashback sets in me as total paralysis and derailment. I lose focus. I can't speak. People have told me it looks like the colour has drained from my face, that I look like I'm a thousand miles away, which I might as well be in that moment.

This mental mapping and struggle out of the dungeon is my first and primary ritual. It is a simple and effective way to compartmentalise pain and give myself distance. I learned that tool on my own to manage anxiety or desperation and break up obsessive loops around negative, destructive feelings. Many years later I would learn just the compartmentalisation tool again in cognitive behavioural therapy and realise I had been doing such imaginative self-preservation rituals for years.

I now see that I have relied on forms of such simulation-based

healing in the absence of therapy and a supportive social network, which my chronic depression often weakens dramatically. Working through trauma demands space and time, financial security, and professionally-trained, profoundly empathic listeners. It requires education in emotional intelligence and a reliable safety net. Most people in America have limited or non-existent access to most of these things. So when overwhelmed or spiralling, I would (at ten, at fifteen, at twenty, at twenty-five) go and sit down cross-legged in a quiet room, then press play on a walkthrough. I had many set pieces, depending on need, some more soothing and cool than the dungeon, the spatial equivalent of a ten-hour psytrance meditation video on Youtube: a seaside forest with brisk streams running through it; a cavernous medieval court; or a trail through hills in Hawaii leading to a ledge on which I watched the ocean crash over a house, flood it, loosen its foundation, and drag all its contents out to sea. After more extreme violence, I needed more elaborate walkthroughs. I would slot the vile trauma into a form, place the form into the dungeon, then manage the form through creating space between.

I am not sure when the dungeon became my main go-to of these sets. I do know how it has developed over time. I call the dungeon retreat and the following ascension out of it the Undoing. The Undoing evolved into a complex and knotty set piece that could jumpstart my own creative process. And—now I see this—my need and commitment to be creative and generative was directly linked to the origin experience of trauma or erasure.

Allow me a quick mini-walkthrough of my CPTSD here. CPTSD wracks my mental undercarriage to such a degree that processing and resolving basic, offhand slights and offences becomes very difficult. A hypersexualised advertising image

that seems to valorise assault, a slightly too-sharp tone of voice—these can all deconstruct my peace and focus for the whole day. These instances—what's one day?—may not seem like much, but days add up to weeks add up to years.

And then there are all the casual erasures by intimates, the dismissals by professional acquaintances, the accretive small violences common to the daily experience of women of colour. The fact of my origin actually says nothing substantive about me, other than what I want it to, but in writing it out, it is inevitably a marker that overdetermines 'who I am' to some reading, precluding the possibility of self-definition. Stating the fact is its own double bind, but it has to be made explicit for this essay to make sense to the people I write for. The page generates the same suffocating issues as in life. Identity, like trauma, is ultimately an endlessly mineable resource for publishers, for editors, who care most about cultivating a woke look. I speak to define myself but I am reified by my choice of words.

Living in a psychic underworld of a billion microaggressions endemic to living in a country and civilisation built on white supremacy: this is the baseline. Such fun! The baseline is the indecent, violent freedom others feel to erase the truth of my experience and feelings and perspective because (if we dig down to the foundation) they do not see me as real. That is it. At least a couple of times a day, I'm on the receiving end of a phrase or statement that emphatically denies my inner life, that denies my humanity, my creativity, my value, and my ownership of my ideas. Casually buried in an e-mail, in a message, in an off-hand remark, a denial of my possible singularity in favour of such incredibly boring assumptions and tropes and stories about who I am, what people generally like me must be like.

And there is nothing worse than a boring story.

Such fun! I wrote above, and this is of course some more deflection, as you'll just die without laughing at it all. I'd just die. Such fun, I wrote, but could it, in fact, be a kind of perverse fun? Could it all be a matter of fighting cleverly enough, nimbly enough, out of the dungeon, knowing full well that each time that you'll die and start at the beginning again? Why do people play *Dark Souls II*, if not for the possibility of a more elegant, longer run-through with fewer deaths and less psychic harm?

The stairway begins to narrow, and a small rectangle of light appears. The noises have faded. I follow this stone staircase, spiralling up, and pass through the light. The stairs lead outside and hug the long curve of the castle. The camera's eye scales out of my perspective to a god's-eye view, circling the fortress. I am outside of myself, and I see my small body holding the wall for balance, trying not to look over the edge to the sun dappling the cold glittering water below. I watch my little body inching up and around the curved wall.

When I reach the terrace, the camera slots back to my eyes. I look down as I walk, notice how the rough stone ends precisely at the vertex of a burnt orange triangle, which reveals itself as one of ten in a gorgeous tiled compass. I walk to the centre of the compass and look out to the sea. The terrace circles around the fortress tower and is a cross between Robert Irwin's Central Garden at the Getty and the overlook at Hearst Castle—the former built for people to reflect on their relation to light and sound, their being-ness, and the latter for a media baron to look

over his domain (America), his parties full of expensive and charming people, and the hills of the California Central Coast.

☾

I started playing games at six. Through each successive console, from SNES to Gameboy, the Sega Genesis to PC games like *Doom* and *Diablo*, the dungeon crawler was my favourite genre. Though I was too young for the dungeon crawler's Golden Age (yes, there is a golden age), its effect can be traced in every role-playing game and war fantasy in the next twenty-odd years of increasingly elaborate titles. In the early dungeon crawler's simplest form, the protagonist just had to escape and successfully erase the obstacles thrown into his path. The plot was not really the point, but instead, the immense pleasure of the labyrinth's complexity, the pleasure of surrendering to the demands of strategy.

Having played since I was so little, it seems natural that my still-forming sponge brain absorbed the logic, structures, and mechanics of game worlds. They changed my thinking in an irreversible way, as so much technology shapes us irrevocably. The *automap*—a small partial map on the bottom right of the game screen that opens up through world exploration—has become the subconscious or background framework I see through, opening the possibility of new landscapes for endless psychodrama to unfold upon, changing the meaning of the psychodrama. My personal conflict means so much less within a ruined city, up against the epic of transatlantic trade routes, or underwater in a submarine.

My daily lived psychic reality intersects well with the overall beautiful logics and patterns of war games. Spending thousands

of hours running through three-dimensional models reveals the 'real world', as it is also a system, a maze, a grid of objects to contend with, analyse, and define on an emerging internal map. I can find a way to gain agency in its bounded space and then try to transfer those lessons out into the world.

The foremost beauty of games to me is how they can model ambiguity as a role. The roles within a game don't need to be so precisely defined; in fact, the mechanics are built to make modularity a feature. I can be a man, a tank, a tree; I can be tall, short, strongly built, weak; I can take whatever form fits my inner life. Games' most fantastical and outright surrealist characters morph and die and resurrect in dozens of forms. A game character's physical presentation usually isn't aligned with their actual (internal, spiritual, emotional) powers. The humble chambermaid can be the most radical and all-seeing player, a visionary. The daughter needing to be saved can cause incredible chaos, controlling from her seemingly submissive position. The dog can be a prophet. The land can heal itself.

So on the terrace, I can be the main warrior, sure, but also be the blacksmith, the archivist, the scribe, the shipbuilder. I can be both a knight and a queen. I can be the enforcer tying the community together or the alien mage passing through with one vital piece of information. And there is my ideal possibility, to become the joker, a trickster, like Loki, who intervenes at will, who absorbs nothing harmful, who elides, who creates on their own terms, who doesn't have to play the game at all.

The terrace air is clean. There are men and women in hooded gowns, crimson, black, purple, like the ones I wore in lower

school during the Christmas parade, which wound through Ghent in colonial Norfolk. We wore hooded gowns like these, carrying candles to the Episcopal church to sing. They look up at me and right through me. Their faces flicker between being all smiles and open curiosity to being retiring, closed off. They symbolise commitment, their lifetimes spent in pursuit of strange feelings and ways of seeing. They shuffle around, in one hand a book, a pen, or an empty sheet of paper. Though they are old, they still say that they are learning, that they know nothing at all. They have spent decades contemplating God, the nature of reality, the arcane, in gnostic isolation, indifferent to the world. In games, they manifest as infuriating oracles who answer in ambivalent riddles. They aren't there to help or guide. They are just there to demonstrate the sublimity of detachment from being too in the world, to contemplate, catalogue, and generate new languages, fictions.

☾

This terrace is my space of retreat after the full Undoing is complete. Not-yet born ideas incubate in tiger's eye, capping the stone balustrade at intervals. The first ideas are cherished for being untested, for being raw seeds. The terrace is completely mine, where my role is as I define it. I inhabit the costume I want, the flesh I want, the voice I want. I can be monstrous and endless, or I can be a speck of dust. I do not have to be anyone for anyone. I do not have to speak in any particular way to please any particular person.

In creating and navigating these controlled spaces of undoing—the dungeon, the stairwell leading to the terrace overlooking the ocean—to cope with trauma, I found a way to write myself

out of uninteresting framings of my inner life. By the time I have gotten to the terrace, I have shed not only the original trauma, but how others in my real life have foisted roles on me, either in ignorance or intentionally. I imagine myself shedding all the remnants of a colonised mind and colonised thinking, all the images, tropes, and roles that do not serve me. What remains? What is now possible in this blank space?

On the terrace, I feel blank and calm. I feel at ease with doubt, with uncertainty, with half-formed thoughts. Offences and pain pass through me as easily as through a sieve. I reserve any certitude that I really know certain things, that my path is set out for me, that there is a proscribed set of possibilities for how my life will turn out. On the terrace I feel sure of the radical possibility inherent both in me and in the people around me, my students, my family, my friends.

There are many healing, generative effects that emerge from this undoing and following blankness, especially for writing. The blankness allows for doubt of language's sole grip on defining reality. The other figures on the terrace: their sentences mean one hundred things at once. In order to ever write about ideas that I did not yet have language for at the time of writing, I had to reject academic, canon-based ideas of which stories were even worth telling. And it will take a lifetime to sort through the imperialist aesthetics and values that shape which languages our cultural gatekeepers can even hear, register, understand.

In one of my favourite sermons, T. D. Jakes describes one's life as a massive bow and arrow. The amount of struggle we endure pulls back the bowstring, deeper and deeper, causing one's life, the arrow, to fly further, on fire, in the direction of one's talent and dreams. I also see the amount of work I've described in

the Undoing, the labour it takes for a marginalised mind and body to climb out of the pits, scale the walls up to the terrace into a state of integrity, into a state of clarity, to be able to make anything at all, as directly proportional to the number of risks they might and do take in making.

Ultimately, the terrace is where I feel most strongly that it *matters* to struggle to make art in my way, with my own voice. To erase ventriloquism in myself. To ever examine why I am speaking, with claims to what, to what end, in service of what power. The terrace is the space to imagine alternative futures for others suffering around me. Making anew is really making for a more bearable lived reality in my body. Making what I feel called to make is how I can honour the silences the brilliant women before me endured, and the many dreams they had to give up.

The terrace is the free place I must make sure is always waiting for my return after months and months of distraction, of being hobbled at the knees by depression. After years of constantly being in my own way, of not letting the doors below just slam down so I can *move*. Of not looking at the automap to see that the edge is an unseen door, a way into the divine, the big, big love.

Somewhere in my psyche, I'm sure, the drive to continue being an artist, to build things of worth, stems from trying to change the meaning of the past. I write about children, to imagine other ways things could have been for me. I write the stories I needed to read when I was younger. I try, as difficult as it is, to write as here about creatively coping with trauma to give someone else like me a glimpse of other paths out of the banality of violence that don't involve self-harm, self-immolation. In this mapping

I find alternative endings. In those endings, a kind of correction and absolution.

☾

The fortress expands. Its terrace stretches out to the horizon. A statue of a goddess appears. Titanic, one hundred feet high, Durga or Athena or Az'rael, depending on my moment's psychological and emotional need. Whichever form, she is my highest angel, and her civilisation-ending statue rotates slowly, twists out of the compass as she ascends into the star-studded night, ribbons of plasma spiralling around her. She is my ikon, my model for the depth of understanding, compassion, rigour, honesty, and power that I must draw on in the face of audacious erasures. You cannot erase Durga! She is eternal.

Around her, the gowned figures float as celestial beings, their faces more clear, their names visible in the sky behind them. Watching her rotate in my mind, my body separates and transmutes into rings of light that expand like smoke circles over the sea. I want to only ever come here to think about unseen things. I want to walk out of the dungeon again and again, no matter how many deaths are imprinted on the pillar in that coastal town.